Hard to Get or Hard to Read?
Strategic Ambiguity in Dartmouth Dating Culture

Raúl, Ganza, Despoina & James

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Caroline Hammond

Abstract

This paper looks at "playing hard to get" as a strategic behavior in dating. The basic idea is that people may deliberately act less interested, less available, or slower to respond in order to seem more desirable or avoid emotional risk. Rather than treating this as just a personality trait, this project examines it as a game in which each person's behavior depends on the likely response of the other person and on the broader dating norms around them. We examine this specifically within the Dartmouth undergraduate community, where Greek and non-Greek social spaces create distinct dating environments that may reward the strategy very differently. Using a signaling-game framework, we model "hard to get" as a game that can signal selectivity, confidence, or disinterest, depending on interpretation. We then discuss the results of our survey, which show that Dartmouth undergraduates all prefer clear communication, but the majority of them have acted "hard to get" at least once in the past. So, we conclude that people choose this strategy because they assume it works on others, not because it actually works on them. We also find that being involved in Greek or non-Greek spaces has no influence on the strategy or interpretation chosen.

1 Introduction

Undoubtedly, modern dating often comes with some sort of emotional ambiguity. Communication between interested parties, especially in the early stages of attraction, is shaped by incentives and social norms, constituting dating a simulation of a strategic game. Behaviors such as delayed responses, hiding interest, and emotional withholding are, therefore, not random personality traits, but rather deliberate signaling strategies aimed at making one's self more desirable and/or decreasing one's fear of rejection. "Playing hard to get" is a very common social behavior, but people usually talk about it casually rather than as a strategic interaction. In many dating contexts, people often do not simply act according to how much they like someone. Instead, they may delay replies or act less available in order to appear more desirable and influence how they are perceived. That makes this phenomenon particularly interesting for evolutionary game theory, because each person's choice depends on what they think the other person will do and on what kinds of behavior are rewarded in the broader dating environment.

2 Results

2.1 Model Setup

Our main model was set up to include two strategies: Signaling Interest (hereinafter SI) and Signaling Distance (hereinafter SD). SI includes quick replies, clear communication, direct communication of availability and people being clear about their intentions. On the other hand, SD includes behaviors like delayed responses, intentional ambiguity, and selective availability. The underlying assumptions of our model are that the interactions between eligible participants are random within subpopulations with limited mixing between Greek and non-Greek life populations. Moreover, we assume that there are repeated encounters with potential partners and that the payoffs depend on interpretation and social context. We create a parameters table to formalize these dynamics. The parameters table captures the probability that SD is interpreted correctly, the emotional cost of uncertainty, the reputational gain from appearing selective, the frequency of SD in the population, and the degree of mixing between populations– in this case, between Greek and non-Greek life participants. Overall, Table 1 includes parameters that could emotionally or socially influence whether SD has a positive or negative payoff.

Parameter	**Meaning**
p	Probability SD is interpreted correctly
c	Emotional cost of uncertainty
r	Reputational gain from appearing selective
x	Frequency of SD in population
m	Degree of mixing between populations

Table 1: Parameters Table

2.2 Payoff Matrix

We create a simple, basic matrix with the baseline payoffs for the interactions between the two strategies. Rows represent the strategy chosen by Player 1, while columns represent the strategy chosen by Player 2. Each cell reports the payoff to Player 1 followed by the payoff to Player 2. We define 1 representing a successful romantic interaction with clear communication and intentionality and we let it be the baseline payoff. We let r be the reputational gain from appearing selecting and/or distant, c be the emotional cost borne by an individual due to uncertainty, and p be the probability that SD is interpreted correctly, as a mechanism of "playing hard to get". Then, the payoff matrix looks like:

	SI	**SD**
SI	$(1, 1)$	$1-c,\ p(1+r)+(1-p)(-c)$
SD	$p(1+r)+(1-p)(-c),\ 1-c$	$p(1+r-c)+(1-p)(-c),\ p(1+r-c)+(1-p)(-c)$

Table 2: Payoff Matrix

Now, let us move on to an interpretation of each of those strategies and the expected payoffs. We observe that when two people choose to employ the SI strategy, each one of them receives the

baseline payoff of 1. When Player 2 chooses to opt out of SI and instead employ the SD strategy, then he benefits if communication, or lack thereof, is interpreted correctly. With probability p, they receive the baseline payoff plus the reputational gain. With probability $1-p$, they create the emotional cost $-c$. The SI player, on the other hand, experiences a $1-c$ payoff, since the other player is signaling distance and there is the emotional cost c associated with that which needs to be subtracted from the baseline payoff 1. Now, when Player 1 is SD and Player 2 is SI, the same interaction as described above takes place, but it is reversed. When both players employ distant signaling, with the probability that SD is interpreted correctly, we see that the players gain reputational gain r but still have some emotional cost c. With the probability of wrong interpretation of communication being $1-p$, both players just bear the emotional cost $-c$. Therefore, SD only works when p and r are high enough to outweigh c.

2.3 Replicator Dynamics

Now that we have the model's basic setup, we can proceed to move from one interaction to the whole population and the evolution of the strategies. We define x as the portion of the population that uses SD. $1-x$ is, therefore, the portion of the population using SI. The expected payoff for SI is:

$$\pi_{\text{SI}} = (1-x)(1) + x(1-c) \iff \pi_{\text{SI}} = 1 - cx \tag{1}$$

The expected payoff for SD is:

$$\pi_{\text{SD}} = (1-x)\big[p(1+r)+(1-p)(-c)\big]+x\big[p(1+r-c)+(1-p)(-c)\big] \iff \pi_{\text{SD}} = p(1+r)-(1-p)c-xpc \tag{2}$$

The average population payoff is:

$$\bar{\pi} = x\pi_{\text{SD}} + (1-x)\pi_{\text{SI}} \tag{3}$$

The replicator equation is:

$$\dot{x} = x(\pi_{\text{SD}} - \bar{\pi}) \iff \dot{x} = x(1-x)(\pi_{\text{SD}} - \pi_{\text{SI}}) \tag{4}$$

The replicator equation tells us how fast strategy SD can spread throughout the population, with SD=SI meaning that the population is in equilibrium. Therefore, from equations (1) and (2) SD spreads when SD > SI, or $p(1+r)-(1-p)c-xpc > 1-cx$. Or, in other words, if SD performs better, more people adopt it. If it performs worse, it will start disappearing from the population.

2.4 Model Results

We then simulated these replicator dynamics using the values estimated from our survey: the probability that SD is read correctly, $p \approx 0.15$; the emotional cost of uncertainty, $c \approx 0.7$; and the reputational gain from appearing selective, $r \approx 0.5$. The results of these simulations are shown in Figure 1.

The simulation produces three main results, all consistent with the survey. First, hard-to-get can't take over: from any starting mix, the population always converges to everyone signaling interest. Second, at our survey values it can't even get a foothold with $p \approx 0.15$, Strategic Distance cannot spread into a group of direct communicators and instead dies out. Third, the strategy would need to be read correctly far more often to survive: it only persists once p rises above roughly 0.77, whereas in our survey it is read correctly just about 15% of the time. The takeaway is that because the signal is so rarely interpreted as intended, evolutionary pressure pushes the population toward clear communication.

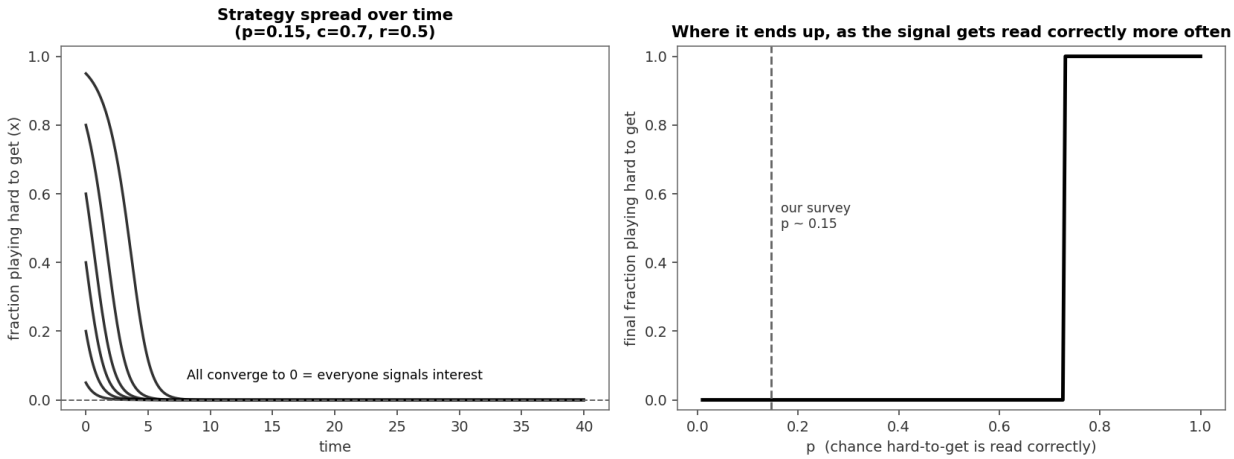


Figure 1: Replicator dynamics with survey-estimated values ($p \approx 0.15$, $c \approx 0.7$, $r \approx 0.5$). Left: the fraction of the population playing hard to get over time, from several starting mixes. Right: the final fraction playing hard to get as the chance the signal is read correctly (p) increases, with our survey value marked.

2.5 Survey Results

The first set of survey results examines whether "playing hard to get" appears as an intentional communication strategy among respondents. This step is important because the model depends on the assumption that Strategic Distance is not simply accidental delayed communication, but a behavior that individuals may deliberately adopt in order to influence how they are perceived. In the survey, respondents were asked whether they had ever intentionally delayed responding to someone they were romantically interested in, why they did so, how likely they were to communicate directly when interested, and which communication style they found most attractive early in dating. These questions correspond directly to the distinction between Signaling Interest and Strategic Distance in the model.

The responses suggest that Strategic Distance is common, though not universally used. Out of 41 respondents, 58.5% reported that they had intentionally delayed responding to someone they were romantically interested in either frequently or sometimes. Another 29.3% said they had done so rarely, while only 12.2% said they had never intentionally delayed a response. This means that nearly 88% of respondents had engaged in intentional delayed communication at least once. This finding supports the model's basic assumption that delayed communication can function as a strategic behavior rather than simply as an accidental feature of texting or busyness.

The stated reasons for delaying responses also support the interpretation of Strategic Distance as socially motivated. Among respondents who gave a reason, the most common explanation was "to avoid seeming too interested," selected by 23 respondents. This is especially important for the model because it suggests that individuals are aware that direct interest may carry a perceived social cost. The second most common reason was "because I didn't know if the other person was as interested," selected by 21 respondents, showing that uncertainty about the other person's feelings can motivate ambiguous behavior. Another 12 respondents selected "because it is socially expected," while 11 respondents selected "to protect myself emotionally." These responses suggest that Strategic Distance serves multiple functions: it can protect individuals from vulnerability, help them manage uncertainty, and allow them to conform to perceived dating norms.

At the same time, the results also show that delayed responses are not always purely strategic.

18 respondents selected "I was genuinely busy" as a reason for delayed communication. This matters because it complicates the interpretation of SD behavior. In the model, the success of Strategic Distance depends on whether delayed communication is interpreted correctly. However, if delayed replies can be caused by both intentional strategy and ordinary busyness, then receivers face an interpretive problem. A delayed response may signal selectivity, uncertainty, lack of interest, or simply a busy schedule. This ambiguity is exactly what makes p, the probability that SD is correctly interpreted, central to the model.

The survey also shows that respondents do not entirely reject direct communication. When asked how likely they are to communicate directly when interested, the average response was approximately 3.32 out of 5, with a median of 3. This suggests that respondents are somewhat mixed: many value or practice direct communication, but not overwhelmingly. Similarly, when asked which communication style is generally more attractive early in dating, 58.5% selected direct and consistent communication, while 22.0% selected slight emotional ambiguity, and 17.1% said it depends on the person. Only 2.4% were unsure, and no respondents selected fully "hard-to-read behavior" as the most attractive option.

This result is important because it suggests that Strategic Distance is not attractive when taken to an extreme. Respondents may sometimes use delayed replies or ambiguity, but most do not report preferring highly unclear or distant behavior. Instead, the results point toward a more conditional pattern: slight ambiguity may be attractive or strategically useful in some cases, but direct and consistent communication remains broadly preferred. This supports the idea that SD is not likely to be a universally dominant strategy. Rather, its payoff depends on context, interpretation, and degree.

This tension is central to the model: Strategic Distance may offer advantages when it creates selectivity or protects against vulnerability, but it becomes less effective when ambiguity is too strong or when direct communication is preferred. In evolutionary game theory terms, these findings suggest that SD may persist in the population, but only as a conditionally successful strategy rather than as a universally stable one.

2.6 Signal Interpretation and Strategic Ambiguity

The next set of results examines how respondents interpret ambiguous communication, especially delayed replies. This section corresponds to the model parameter p, which represents the probability that Strategic Distance is correctly interpreted as intentional rather than accidental or as simple disinterest. This parameter is central to the model because Strategic Distance only produces a payoff advantage when the receiver understands the behavior as selectivity or controlled ambiguity. If the same behavior is interpreted as lack of interest, the strategy loses much of its value.

The survey results suggest that delayed communication is difficult to interpret reliably. When asked what their first assumption would be if someone took a long time to respond, 56.1% of respondents said they would assume the person was not interested. Only 14.6% said they would assume the person was trying to seem hard to get, while 12.2% assumed the person was busy and 17.1% were unsure. This finding is important because it suggests that the signal produced by Strategic Distance is often not interpreted in the way the sender may intend. Although delayed replies may be used strategically, receivers are more likely to interpret them as rejection than as intentional selectivity.

This creates a clear sender-receiver mismatch. In the previous section, we found that 58.5% of respondents had intentionally delayed responding either frequently or sometimes. However, only

14.6% of respondents said that their first interpretation of delayed replies would be that the other person was trying to seem hard to get. In other words, many people use delayed communication strategically, but relatively few people instinctively read delayed communication as strategic. This mismatch directly supports one of the central concerns of the model: Strategic Distance can only be effective when it is socially legible. When the behavior is misread, the payoff of SD decreases.

The scale responses further support this interpretation. When asked how often they interpret delayed replies as intentional rather than accidental, the average response was approximately 2.98 out of 5, with a median of 3. Most respondents clustered around the middle of the scale rather than at the high end. Specifically, 43.9% selected 3, 29.3% selected 4, 22.0% selected 2, and 4.9% selected 1. No respondents selected 5. This suggests that respondents do sometimes recognize delayed replies as intentional, but they do not do so with strong confidence or consistency. As a result, p appears to be moderate at best rather than high.

Respondents also viewed the effectiveness of "playing hard to get" as conditional. When asked whether the strategy usually works, 56.1% said sometimes, while 22.0% said rarely and 22.0% said no. No respondents answered yes. This is one of the most useful findings for the model because it strongly suggests that Strategic Distance is not perceived as a universally successful strategy. Instead, respondents seem to understand its effectiveness as context-dependent: it may work under some circumstances, but it can also fail when the ambiguity becomes too difficult, frustrating, or easy to misinterpret.

Overall, these results suggest that Strategic Distance faces a serious interpretability problem. While many respondents report using delayed communication intentionally, most do not automatically interpret delayed replies from others as strategic. This lowers the expected payoff of SD and supports the idea that "playing hard to get" is conditionally effective rather than universally stable. In evolutionary game theory terms, SD can persist only when the probability of correct interpretation is high enough to offset the risk that ambiguity will be perceived as disinterest.

2.7 Emotional Costs of Uncertainty

The next set of results examines the emotional costs associated with unclear romantic communication. In the model, this corresponds to the parameter c, which represents the cost of uncertainty. This parameter is important because Strategic Distance only remains advantageous if the benefits of appearing selective or desirable outweigh the frustration, confusion, or emotional stress produced by ambiguity. If uncertainty becomes too costly, then the payoff of Strategic Distance decreases, especially when both individuals use it at the same time.

The survey results suggest that unclear communication carries a high emotional cost for most respondents. When asked how emotionally stressful they find unclear romantic communication, 75.6% of respondents selected either 4 or 5 on a 5-point scale, where 5 meant "extremely stressful." The average response was approximately 4.02 out of 5, with a median of 4. This indicates that ambiguity is not emotionally neutral. Even if delayed replies or emotional distance sometimes increase attraction, they also create significant stress for the receiver.

This emotional cost is also reflected in respondents' reported behavior. When asked whether they had ever lost interest in someone because communication felt too unclear or emotionally distant, 34.1% answered frequently and 46.3% answered sometimes. Combined, this means that 80.5% of respondents had lost interest at least sometimes because of unclear communication. Only 7.3% said this had never happened. This strongly supports the idea that ambiguity can backfire. In terms of the model, as c increases, the expected payoff of Strategic Distance falls because the

receiver becomes less willing to continue the interaction.

The results also show a strong preference for clear interest. When asked which situation they would personally prefer, 90.2% of respondents chose someone who clearly shows interest, while only 9.8% preferred someone who is somewhat difficult to read. This is important because it limits the strategic value of "playing hard to get." While earlier results showed that some respondents use delayed replies intentionally, this finding suggests that most people prefer to receive direct signals of interest. Strategic Distance may therefore be used more as a defensive or reputational strategy than as a communication style people actually enjoy receiving.

The strongest support for the model's payoff structure comes from the question about what happens when both people "play hard to get." A majority of respondents, 58.5%, said that the interaction usually dies out, while 22.0% said communication becomes confusing. Another 19.5% said that one person eventually becomes direct. No respondents said that attraction increases when both people play hard to get. This directly supports the model's assumption that SD-SD interactions produce low payoffs. When both players choose Strategic Distance, ambiguity no longer functions as a selective signal; instead, it creates confusion, inaction, and often the end of the interaction.

Overall, these findings suggest that uncertainty has a significant emotional cost. Strategic Distance may occasionally create attraction or protect individuals from vulnerability, but too much ambiguity appears to reduce romantic payoff by increasing stress and causing people to lose interest. In evolutionary game theory terms, this means SD is unlikely to dominate the population. Its success depends on remaining limited, interpretable, and balanced by some degree of direct communication. Once ambiguity becomes too common or too mutual, the strategy collapses under its own emotional cost.

2.8 Social Context: Greek and Non-Greek Differences

Because our original hypothesis predicted that Strategic Distance may operate differently across social environments, we compared responses between Greek-affiliated and non-Greek respondents. The model proposed that Greek social spaces might make "playing hard to get" more effective because shared norms and repeated social interactions could make ambiguous behavior more legible. In other words, if Greek spaces have stronger common expectations around dating behavior, then delayed replies or selective availability might be more likely to be interpreted as intentional rather than as simple disinterest. This comparison is especially relevant because the project proposal specifically identifies Greek and non-Greek spaces as distinct dating environments that may reward Strategic Distance differently.

The survey results provide only limited support for this hypothesis. Greek-affiliated respondents were not more likely to report using Strategic Distance than non-Greek respondents. Among non-Greek respondents, 64.3% said they had intentionally delayed responding either frequently or sometimes, compared to 55.6% of Greek-affiliated respondents. This suggests that Strategic Distance is not exclusive to Greek dating spaces and may instead reflect a broader pattern in Dartmouth dating culture. Delayed communication appears to be a common strategy across both groups rather than a behavior concentrated in one social environment.

Overall, the Greek/non-Greek comparison suggests that Strategic Distance may be less tied to Greek-specific dating norms than originally predicted. Although Greek social spaces may still shape dating behavior in ways not fully captured by this survey, the results do not show a strong Greek/non-Greek divide in either the use or interpretation of "playing hard to get." For the model,

this means that the payoff of Strategic Distance may depend less on formal social affiliation and more on individual expectations, emotional tolerance, and the general uncertainty of early romantic interactions.

3 Methods

3.1 Data and Context

The survey received 41 total responses from Dartmouth undergraduate students. Respondents were asked about their class year, gender, Greek life affiliation, involvement in Greek social spaces, and current dating situation. These questions were included to provide context for interpreting later results, especially because our model predicts that social environment may affect how "playing hard to get" is interpreted and rewarded. The project specifically compares Greek and non-Greek dating spaces because the proposal hypothesizes that shared social norms may make Strategic Distance more legible in some environments than others.

Overall, the sample provides a useful but limited snapshot of Dartmouth dating culture. Because the survey was distributed through informal outreach and snowball sampling, the responses should not be interpreted as fully representative of the entire undergraduate population. However, the sample is still appropriate for the purposes of this project because it includes variation in Greek affiliation, Greek social involvement, dating status, and class year. These differences allow us to examine whether Strategic Distance functions differently across social contexts and whether ambiguity is interpreted as desirable, confusing, or emotionally costly. Table 3 summarizes the composition of the sample across class year, gender, and Greek affiliation.

Variable	**Category**	**Count**	**Percentage**
Class Year	2026	11	26.8%
	2027	10	24.4%
	2028	15	36.6%
	2029	5	12.2%
Gender	Woman	22	53.7%
	Man	19	46.3%
Greek Affiliation	Yes	27	65.9%
	No	14	34.1%

Table 3: Summary Statistics from Survey Results

3.2 Survey Design

We designed the survey so that each question would map onto a specific component of the model rather than asking about "playing hard to get" in the abstract. Questions about whether respondents had intentionally delayed a reply, and why, were intended to establish that Strategic Distance is a deliberate strategy rather than accidental behavior, which is the assumption the SI/SD distinction rests on. Questions about how respondents interpret a slow reply from someone else were designed to estimate p, the probability that Strategic Distance is read correctly, since the payoff of SD depends entirely on this interpretation. Questions about how stressful unclear communication

feels, and whether respondents had lost interest because of it, were designed to capture c, the emotional cost of uncertainty. Finally, questions about preferred communication styles and about what happens when both people play hard to get were included to test the model's prediction that mutual SD produces a low payoff. We chose this design because it lets us connect self-reported behavior directly to the model's parameters, rather than relying on a single global judgment of whether the strategy "works."

3.3 Game Simulation

To move from the analytic model to concrete predictions, we implemented the replicator dynamics in Python, using `NumPy` for the numerical integration, `SymPy` for the symbolic equilibrium analysis, and `Matplotlib` to produce the figures. We parameterized the simulation with values estimated from the survey: $p \approx 0.15$, taken from the 14.6% of respondents who read a slow reply as an attempt to seem hard to get; $c \approx 0.7$, reflecting the 75.6% who rated unclear communication as highly stressful; and $r \approx 0.5$, a modest reputational gain from appearing selective. We chose to estimate the parameters directly from survey responses, rather than assume them, so that the simulation would reflect the actual dating environment we measured rather than a hypothetical one.

The simulation has two parts. First, we integrated the replicator equation forward in time from a range of starting points $x_0 \in (0, 1)$ to see whether Strategic Distance spreads or dies out under the survey values. Second, we held c and r fixed and swept p across its full range, recording the equilibrium fraction of SD at each value, in order to identify the threshold level of correct interpretation that the strategy would need in order to survive. We also solved the equilibrium condition $\pi_{\mathrm{SD}} = \pi_{\mathrm{SI}}$ symbolically as a check on the numerical results. This combination of a time-course simulation and a parameter sweep was chosen so that the conclusion would not depend on any single value of p: the sweep shows the full relationship between interpretation and the strategy's survival, with our survey estimate marked as one point along it.

4 Discussion

4.1 Prior Work and Our Contribution

Prior research established that playing hard to get can make a single person more appealing: selectiveness and a degree of mystery can signal value, and a partner's uncertainty about how much they are liked can itself increase attraction [1, 2]. That literature also emphasized two qualifications, namely that the effect holds only in moderation and that it depends heavily on the receiver, particularly their attachment style and tolerance for uncertainty. What this work did not address is what happens when the strategy is not the behavior of one clever individual but the behavior of a whole dating community. Our contribution is to scale the question up. By embedding Signaling Interest and Signaling Distance in a replicator model and estimating its parameters from a survey of the population we are interested in, we can ask not only whether the strategy can work on one person, but whether it can spread and stabilize when many people adopt it. The central finding is that these two questions have opposite answers: Strategic Distance can win an individual interaction, yet it cannot take over the population. The behavior that looks adaptive up close turns out to be self-limiting in the aggregate.

4.2 Why the Strategy Works Individually but Fails Collectively

The reason for this gap is interpretation. In the model, Strategic Distance produces a payoff advantage only when it is read as selectivity, desirability, or controlled emotional independence, which is captured by the probability p that the signal is decoded correctly. The survey shows that this condition is rarely met. Although 58.5% of respondents reported intentionally delaying replies, only 14.6% would read a delayed reply from someone else as an attempt to seem hard to get, while 56.1% would read it as simple disinterest. This sender–receiver mismatch is the heart of the result: people send the signal far more often than they receive it as intended, so the same behavior that one person hopes will read as confidence usually reads as rejection. Because p is low, the expected payoff of SD falls below that of clear communication, and the strategy is selected against.

The emotional cost of ambiguity, captured by c, deepens the problem. Respondents overwhelmingly preferred clear interest (90.2%), found unclear communication stressful (75.6% rating it 4 or 5 out of 5), and frequently lost interest when communication became too ambiguous (80.5% at least sometimes). The decisive evidence is what respondents reported about mutual Strategic Distance: when both people play hard to get, no respondent said attraction increases, and most said the interaction simply dies out or becomes confusing. This is exactly the low-payoff SD–SD cell the payoff matrix predicts. It means the strategy performs worst precisely when it is most common, which builds a ceiling into its own spread. Signaling Interest, by contrast, yields a stable baseline payoff in SI–SI interactions through clarity and lower emotional cost. SI is not perfectly dominant, since an SD player can still gain against a direct communicator who reads the ambiguity positively, but the overall picture is one in which clear communication is the resting state and ambiguity persists only at the margins.

4.3 The Model and the Survey Agree

The replicator simulation makes this argument quantitative and confirms it. Using the survey-estimated values $p \approx 0.15$, $c \approx 0.7$, and $r \approx 0.5$, the dynamics converge from any starting mixture to a population in which everyone signals interest, and Strategic Distance cannot even gain a foothold among direct communicators. The parameter sweep shows why: the strategy survives only once p rises above roughly 0.77, far above the observed rate of about 15%. In other words, the survey tells us that the signal is usually misread, and the model tells us that a signal misread this often cannot evolve into a population norm. The two halves of the project reach the same conclusion from different directions. From an evolutionary game theory perspective, SD is therefore not a pure Evolutionarily Stable Strategy. For SD to be stable on its own it would need to consistently outperform Signaling Interest when common, and both the data and the dynamics show it does the opposite, declining in value as it becomes more widespread.

4.4 What Does Not Explain the Strategy

We also tested whether social context rescues the strategy, and found that it largely does not. We originally hypothesized that Greek social spaces, with stronger shared norms and repeated interactions, would make Strategic Distance more legible and therefore more stable. The survey did not support this: Greek-affiliated respondents were no more likely than non-Greek respondents to use or correctly interpret SD (56% versus 64% reporting frequent or occasional use). This suggests that the fragility of the strategy is not an artifact of any one social environment but a more general feature of how the signal is read. The one dimension along which behavior did differ

was gender. Women used the strategy more often (68% versus 47% of men) and were more likely to read a slow reply as deliberate (23% versus 5%), while men more strongly preferred directness (74% versus 46%). These differences are suggestive given the small sample, but they matter for the model because they imply that p is not uniform across the population. If women both use and recognize the strategy more readily, the effective interpretation rate may be higher within some interactions than others, and the single pooled value we estimated may mask real heterogeneity, leaving SD more viable in some subgroups than the aggregate dynamics suggest. Gender, rather than formal group affiliation, thus appears to be the more promising axis along which to disaggregate the population in future work.

4.5 Implications

Taken together, the model and the survey suggest that Strategic Distance can survive in the population, but only under limited conditions: it works best when it is rare enough to appear selective, clear enough to be interpreted as intentional, and mild enough not to impose excessive emotional costs. Once too many people use it, or once ambiguity becomes too hard to read, it loses its advantage. The model therefore does not predict that "playing hard to get" should replace direct communication. Instead, it predicts a mixed equilibrium in which clear communication remains broadly preferred while strategic ambiguity persists at low frequency because it can occasionally generate a social or romantic payoff. This reframes the everyday intuition behind the behavior. People keep playing hard to get because they assume it works on others, and against a single receiver it sometimes does; but because almost everyone misreads the signal when they are on the receiving end, the strategy cannot become how a whole community behaves. In this sense the survey supports the central evolutionary claim of the project: "playing hard to get" is neither irrational nor universally effective, but a frequency-dependent strategy whose payoff depends on interpretation, emotional cost, and social context.

5 Limitations and Next Steps

Several limitations qualify these conclusions. The survey drew only 41 respondents recruited by word of mouth, so the gender and Greek-affiliation patterns are suggestive rather than confirmed. We also measured "playing hard to get" mainly through delayed replies, capturing only one part of the behavior. And a delayed reply is ambiguous, it may signal strategy or simple busyness, which our survey cannot fully separate. This is not just a measurement issue; it is the interpretive problem at the center of p.

These point to clear next steps. A larger, more randomly recruited sample would let the subgroup differences be confirmed or rejected. A survey design that separates intentional strategy from ordinary busyness would sharpen our estimate of how often the signal is misread. Finally, because men and women used and read the behavior so differently, modeling them as distinct subpopulations rather than one pooled population could reveal asymmetric or sex-specific equilibria, such as a stable arrangement where one group tends to signal distance and the other interest, that the current model cannot capture.

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